

Lesson 4

Reacting vs Responding

Up until this point, we've talked about what really keeps people stuck and what must shift in order for things to change, but none of that makes sense unless you really understand the difference between reacting and responding, because on the surface they look very similar. Like you feel something uncomfortable and you do something, but what you do, and most importantly, the energy behind it matters a lot.

We've already talked a lot about the external behaviors, like researching, checking, reassurance, seeking, you know, what those look like by now. But I wanna talk about what reaction feels like on the inside, because that's what's actually driving the behavior. Reacting has a specific internal quality to it.

There's an urgency underneath it. A very strong feeling like, I need to do something right now. And when that happens, your attention narrows in and the symptom and the sensation become the only thing that you can focus on. Everything else fades into the background. I used to call this. Tunnel vision. I felt like I was in a tunnel and I could not take in anything that was happening around me.

It was a scary place to be. There's like a tightness in your body, bracing, and that's because your system is preparing for a threat. Even if you're just sitting on your couch or laying in your bed, mentally, you're gonna experience a lot of spinning out because you're trying to figure it out. You're running through scenarios.

You're looking for those answers in your own head. You're replaying things and you're projecting all of this onto the future. There's this feeling that you can't rest or move on until this is resolved. Like something is wrong and you are the only one who can fix it, and that if you don't keep working on this problem, something very bad is going to happen in the very near future.

And there's a tricky part to all of this because often all of that internal urgency will bring you relief when you act on it. Because when you Google something and you feel a little better for a minute, you get that reassurance. And the anxiety will drop or you cancel plans and you feel that pressure lift.

You are feeling relief from these behaviors. But relief is not the same thing as safety. Feeling better temporarily. Is different than your system registering that you are safe. So reacting is about escaping the discomfort and every time you escape, you're reaffirming to your nervous system that there was something to escape from.

You are confirming that the discomfort was dangerous. You're telling your brain, you're right on, you were worried. I reacted like this is a problem. You are reading this situation accurately. You're gonna realize that that is why the relief never lasts. You have to keep doing it. You have to keep checking, keep researching, keep seeking reassurance, and that's because you're never conveying.

Adequately that you are, okay. You're just learning that the only way to be okay is to keep reacting through these behaviors and through this internal way of being. So let's talk about the opposite, which is responding. Responding is different. It is something that you choose versus what's happening automatic, and please know that.

What happens automatically is going to happen. It's your job to notice the automatic behavior playing out and choose to respond. Responding is slower even if only by a few seconds. Sometimes that's the case when you're sensitized. We're not gonna be able to take this 15 minute pause, but there's an energy to it that's non-urgent.

It allows discomfort to exist without needing it to stop immediately. It's not trying to resolve the uncertainty you are aiming for a different response here, something that is closer to neutral or indifferent or unbothered by the outcome that is happening right now. And I wanna be very clear with you, because this is extremely hard to do.

When your system has been on high alert for months or years or decades, unbothered feels almost impossible. So I do not want you to think that I'm minimizing right now. I know how horrific this is. It is one of the hardest things you will ever do. But it's also very simple. The feeling shows up, the sensation shows up, the symptom shows up, and you just let it be there.

You don't engage. You don't try to fix it. You don't go to work on it. You acknowledge that it's there and you keep doing whatever you were doing. Now, I know what brains do when I say this. Your brain is probably asking, okay, but how do I do that? How do I not engage? And I wanna be very firm with you here.

There's nothing to figure out here. You just don't engage. You don't need more information on how to do that. That instruction that I gave you is the whole thing. The reason this feels so confusing is because it's hard. It's not because it's complicated and you're sensitized, so it's, it feels even harder.

It's very simple, but your brain is gonna want more steps because if you had more steps, it would give you something to do. But that's the issue here. That's the whole point. There is nothing to do. You feel a feeling or a sensation or a symptom, and you let it. Be there. When you have spent months or years reacting to every sensation, this is going to feel completely unnatural because your whole system has been wired to do something.

So not doing anything is going to feel wrong at first, but wrong doesn't mean unsafe and wrong doesn't mean dangerous, it's just unfamiliar for you. So what does response look like in actual real moments? Because I wanna give you some examples. I don't want this to stay abstract, so I'm trying to be as direct as I can while helping you realize there's no step by step.

There are just examples of responding different in the moment. So these are some of the most common things I hear as far as where people get stuck. So you wake up in the morning and your first thought is about your symptoms. If you were reacting, what you would do is immediately start checking your body, assessing how you feel, deciding is today gonna be a good day, or is it gonna be a bad day?

Responding is noticing that first thought, letting it be there and getting out of bed anyway without doing that mental inventory. The second example is you're in the middle of the day. Maybe you've been having a good day and all of a sudden your sensations start flaring up. Reacting would be, stop what I'm doing, focusing on it.

Try to figure out what caused this. Maybe Google it, maybe text somebody about it. But responding is noticing the sensation, acknowledging, yeah, this is uncomfortable, and continuing with what you are doing. You don't give it your full attention. You let it be in the background. The third thing is you're about to do something.

And you begin to feel anxious, reacting would be, I'm gonna cancel or I'm gonna avoid this, or I'm just gonna wait until I feel better and we'll reschedule. Whereas responding is feeling that anxiety and doing it anyway without needing the anxiety to go away or for you to feel good. The last example is you're lying in bed at night and your mind is racing about your health and whether or not you're gonna sleep tonight.

Reacting would be engaging with those thoughts, trying to reason your way out of them. Doing a lot of self reassurance or picking up your phone and starting to research. Responding is letting those thoughts and letting that fear be there without grabbing onto it. You do not engage. You do not argue. You do not reassure.

You acknowledge that they're there and you realize and trust that they will pass on their own again. None of this is easy, but it is very simple and it's exactly what responding looks like. For a long time, I thought that I was helping myself. I was doing everything I could think of to feel better and to figure out what was wrong.

But again, all of those behaviors were signaling threat to my nervous system. I was not teaching it safety. I was teaching it that we were in danger. Every moment of every day, which is what made my baseline keep climbing. That is what reaction does, even when it brings that relief in the moment. Remember that relief is not safety.

It's just a temporary break from whatever you were experiencing before. Every time you react, you're teaching your nervous system. That discomfort requires you to take immediate action because something is wrong, because we cannot let this be here. And when you do that, the alarm stays on. It's very simple.

It has to stay on because you keep confirming that there's something to be alarmed about. This has been done on your part innocently. Up until now, because now you know what's going on. You know

what needs to be different, and the ball is in your court to start showing up in a new way and behaving different so that you can start signaling safety.

When you work with responding in a new way, you're essentially removing the escape hatch because reacting gives you a way to, to get out of what you're feeling and to get some relief and to get a quick hit of reassurance, and when you stop doing that. The discomfort is not gonna go away immediately.

It's gonna grab on even harder, and a lot of the time it's going to get louder. Before it gets quieter. Your mind is going to protest. It's going to feel like this cannot be what I'm supposed to be doing right now. You're going to feel like I'm ignoring something urgent and important. It's going to feel unsafe.

But it's not unsafe and it's not dangerous. And that's what we need to reteach your mind and your nervous system. You might have thoughts like, but what if this time it's real? What if this time this, it's actually serious and this is a real thing? Or should I at least check just to make sure? Or I mean, everyone else googles their symptoms.

My, my husband doesn't have a problem with it. Why can't I? And I understand those questions because I had all of those questions, but that is your fear talking. And remember, we're trying to recover from that chronic fear, and your fear is going to get louder when you stop feeding it, but I want you to remember that even if it feels like you're doing less or like you're doing nothing, you are doing something, something very specific.

You are breaking the old pattern that keeps this alarm on. You are teaching your nervous system something new. You are rewiring safety. You are telling your nervous system. It is safe for me to live my life. And yes, responding often is going to feel worse before it gets better. I want you to be so ready for that, which is why I keep saying it.

Feeling worse is not a sign that you are doing it wrong. It just is a sign that that recalibration is happening in the background. I wanna talk about a couple mistakes that people make when they're shifting from reaction to responding, because there are a couple ways I see people get tripped up here.

The first one. Is turning, responding into another thing to monitor, because you're gonna start checking whether you're responding correctly, which is the, did I do it right? Question. You're gonna start watching yourself even more to see if you're reacting or responding. That is still reacting. You are just now reacting about your response.

It's tricky. Like I said. The second one is trying to force yourself to feel calm all the time, and that if you're not feeling calm, there's a problem. But responding does not require calm. Calm is not gonna be accessible to you for a while. Be ready for that. 'cause if you're trying to be all tense and forceful of trying to feel peaceful, you're just adding another layer of pressure on top of everything else we're doing here.

It is okay for you to be activated uncomfortable. Even scared and still be responding in a new way. The difference is you're not acting on it. The third one is white knuckling. And this is where you're technically not doing the reactive behavior, but internally you're bracing a ton and clenching and counting it down till it passes and checking in with it and seeing did it get better?

Did it get worse? Did it stay the same? And I just wanna tell you, even if you think you're being tricky, your nervous system is picking up on it. It knows the difference between actually allowing something to be there and you holding your breath until it's over, you're gonna fall into that pattern.

Sometimes it's okay. Again, we're not aiming for perfection here. There isn't a way to do this, right? You are learning how to be different. How to act differently and how to respond differently. The fourth one is just expecting this to work instantly. To apply something one time or to try responding in a new way for a day or two.

And then if you don't feel better, just say, oh yeah, this isn't working for me. This is a long game. The reality. That I wanna be really upfront with you about is that desensitizing, your nervous system is gonna take between one and three years, most likely. And when I say that, I don't mean that you're gonna feel as bad as you do now in year two, but completely desensitizing it.

It takes a long time. So I want you to know that upfront, that this is responding over a long period of time because you are. Rewiring patterns that have been reinforced for months or years or decades. This is not gonna shift in a weekend, but when you put in this work and this change response, over a month, two months, four months, six months, you are gonna begin seeing real changes in what you're experiencing with both your mental symptoms and your physical symptoms, both reaction and response.

Require discomfort. That's not what separates them. The truth is that either way you're going to feel discomfort, but with reacting, you're trying to make that discomfort stop, and with responding, you are letting it be there intentionally on purpose. Reacting comes from a place of, this shouldn't be happening, I need to fix it immediately.

Whereas responding comes from a place of, this is here right now, I'm gonna let it be here. Reaction is automatic response is chosen. You have what you need to begin practicing this. You know what reaction looks like. You know the things you need to stop doing. You also know what responding is, and you have examples of what that looks like in real moments.

Your work now is doing it, noticing when you're reacting automatically and choosing to respond instead again. Again and again, repeat times a thousand. What I wanna talk about in the next lesson is this skill that makes this sustainable over time because choosing to respond is one thing, but choosing it over and over, especially when you feel terrible is another, and that skill is distress tolerance.